

Bringing this kind of detailed drill-down ability to the last mile and enabling the casual consumer of the game see the sport with such extreme detail and convenience would have been impossible without big data. Every delivery ever bowled, every stroke ever played and every catch ever dropped – only because of a mammoth effort at cataloguing all possible detail has the world been rewarded with this magnificent view of the game that is arguably better than the real thing itself.

ESPNcricinfo is not, however, merely a data visualisation web app. Teams will naturally want to extract a lot more than a few colourful bar charts for measuring up their opponents. In exchange for a subscription fee, teams can obtain even deeper analyses and can fine tune the data even more to suit their purposes.

Another attempt at bringing clarity to an otherwise chaotic sport is the recently developed Expected Goals (xG) method of predicting football matches. Several people have developed their own xG models for predicting the final score-line based on the number of shots a team takes in the game, and the model has come under a fair amount of criticism as well. However, it comes with a lot of positives.

First, its aim is simple, and makes footballing sense – predicting the number of goals a team “should have” scored. Shots lead to goals – some shots are more likely to lead to goals than others. The xG method attempts to account for this in several ways – shots from farther out are less likely to be converted than nearer ones, shots taken right in front of goal are better bets than those taken from an angle, and shots taken after a rebound are more likely to catch the defence off-guard than those taken against a prepared defence.

Second, interpreting the results is easy. Comparing expected goals against the actual result of the match, we can tell whether the team underperforms or exceeds expectations. It’s conceptually easy to grasp the idea of a ratio of empirical value divided by a theoretical value as a metric for performance of a team, and the accuracy of the model itself.

Third is the fact that it refers to goals as the objective. It’s common in football for statistics such as ball possession or total passes completed to be emphasised to an unhealthy extent, often without context or consideration towards the nature of those passes or the zones in which the possession was kept. Goals are an objective metric using which football games are decided, and therefore the xG model is pertinent in football analysis and prediction.